

Philosophy

#9:EXISTENTIALISM

SYED NOMAN ALI

LECTURER

MASTER IN PHILOSOPHY, UOK

Critical questions

- *What is the meaning of life?*
- *What is my place or existence in it?*
- *What choices does this obligate me to make ethical?*

Background



- Existentialism is mainly a European philosophy that originated before the turn of the twentieth century, but became popular after World War II (1939 – 45).

- From the scientific viewpoint, man was also regarded as an object. Man became a slave to machines in developing industrial society. In scientific life, the individual is leading a life of tension, worries, frustrations, fear and sense of guilt.

- Against this situation existentialism emerged as a protest against the society and asserted the supremacy of **individuality of man.**

Kierkegaard: Three type of person

1. ***Aesthetic person*** *who live in moment and lack commitment.*
   (Life devoted to pleasures eventually get tired of.)

2. ***Ethical person*** *who is committed to ideals of goodness.*
   (again dutiful only for temporary lead to despair.)

3. ***Religious person*** *who recognize the transcendental nature of true ideals.*
   (take leap of faith so there is no rational reason to religion)

Existentialism

1) *Individual significance*
2) *Irrational aspect of life*
3) *Importance of freedom*



Soren Kierkegaard (1813-1855)

He was the father of existentialism

He rejected Plato and Aristotle (the idea that the essence of something determines what it is… “essence before existence.”)

Believed that individual choice determines essence (existence precedes essence!)

It is a person’s responsibility to live a totally committed (valid) life and should be prepared to defy the norms of society for the sake of that commitment.

We touch reality in intense moments of existence especially moments of painful decision by feeling deep anxiety.

Ideas for existentialism

1. *A man first exists and defines himself afterwards.*
2. *We choose own meaning for existence now .*
3. *You create your own meanings for life to be authentic*
4. *Man is so free but he is fearful of his freedom.*

5.We must minimize the social influences on our actions.

6.We must take responsibility and realize your own potentials.

7.We will not be here forever so find possibilities.

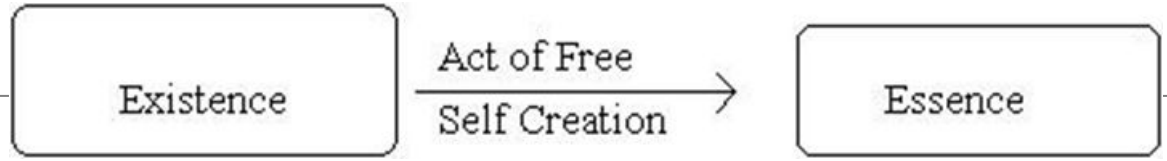
EXISTENCE PRECEDE ESSENCE
Jean Paul Sartre (1905-1980)

- Man is nothing else but what he purposes, he exists only in so far as he realizes himself, he is therefore nothing else but the sum of his actions, nothing else but what his life is."
- IT IS UPTO YOU TO GIVE LIFE A MEANING.
- We are condemned to be free without reasons. He is responsible for what he does.
- What we choose to do determines our nature.
- The decision making process creates our personality and reality.
- We invent our own values .

6 Basic Themes of Existentialism

- 1. Man is conscious subject rather than a thing to be predicted or manipulated.
- 2. Anxiety -- a generalized uneasiness.
- 3. Absurdity -- Each of us is simply here, having been thrown into this time and place, but why now?
- 4. Nothingness -- "I am my own existence, but my existence is nothingness."
- 5. Death -- The only certainty of life which hangs over existentialist head at each moment of life.
- 6. Alienation -- apart from the existentialist's own conscious being, everything else is "otherness", from which he or she estranged.

I-Existence Precedes Essence



This means:

1. We have no predetermined nature or essence that controls what we are, what we do, or what is valuable for us.

2. We are radically free to act independently of determination by outside influences.

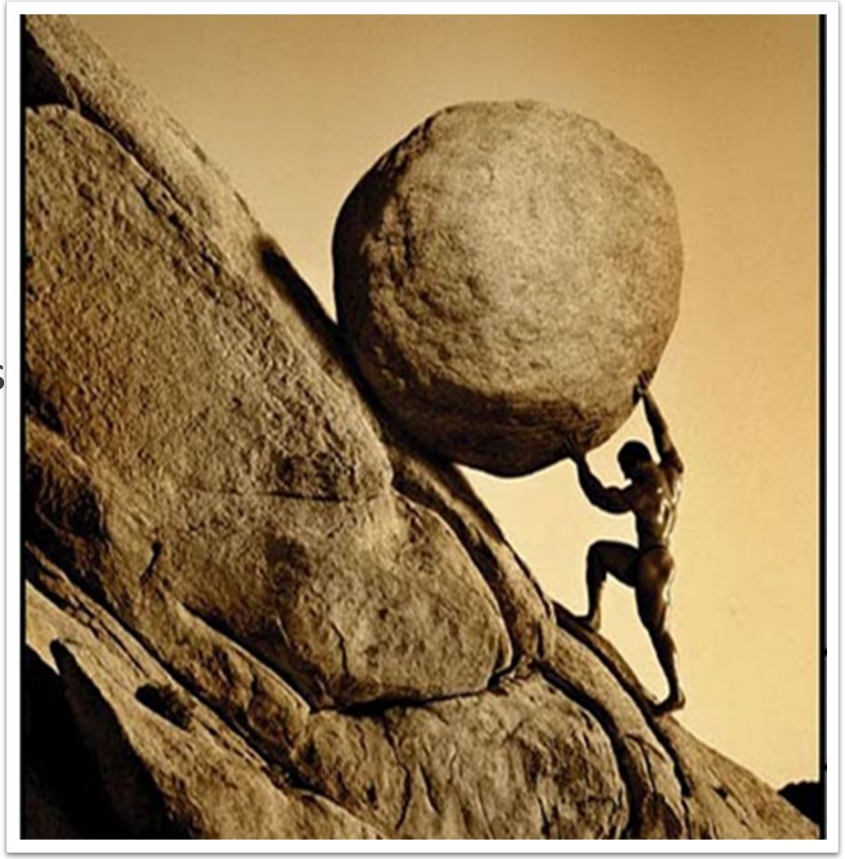
3. We create our own human nature through these free choices.

4. We also create our values through these choices.

5. Humans exist in a meaningless, irrational universe and any search for order will bring them into direct conflict with this universe. The belief that nothing can explain our existence.

II-Absurdity

- Life is absurd and reason is useless in dealing with the depths of human life
- Man seen in this light is full of contradictions.
- Man creates himself through the choices he makes and thus takes responsibility.
- Man is in a paradox, it is evidence shows that the world is unpredictable and chaotic.
- Life comes into existence and then passes.
- Ideas are proven to be true and then determined to be false
- Man tries to make sense of this world.
- This human condition- the constant attempt to derive meaning from the meaninglessness. And thus **it is absurd.**



III- Alienation

- Explores feelings of alienation and isolation resulting from the absurdity of existence.
- Individuals may feel disconnected from others or their own sense of self. The development of science has “separated man from concrete earthy existence.
- We should separate from the influence of society.
- We have collectivized individual man out of existence, driven God from the heavens or from the hearts of men.

IV-Fear, Dread and Anxiety

Anxiety stems from understanding of the total freedom of choice that confronts us every moment, and the individual's confrontation with nothingness.

ANXIETY IS THE DIZNESS OF FREEDOM-KIERKEGAARD

Dread is a feeling of general apprehension to make a commitment to a personally valid way of life.

V-Encounter with Death.

If man is alienated from nature, neighbors, and self, what is left?

Death hangs over all of us. Our awareness of it can bring freedom or anguish.

Confronts the reality of death and the finite nature of human existence.

Awareness of mortality prompts reflection on the meaning of life.



VI-Freedom

- Existentialists write about the enlargement of the range of human freedoms.
- Freedom is the acceptance of responsibility for choice and a commitment to one's choice.
- Emphasizes individual freedom and the responsibility that comes with it.
- Freedom entails making choices and accepting the consequences.
- We are our choices-Sartre



Objections to Existentialism

How do critics challenge Husserl' contention that "bracketing" is presuppositionless and objective?

– What questions do philosophers raise about Sartre's claim that that one cannot be in the mode of being-for-itself by freely choosing to be committed to any other form of group membership?

Existential crisis

Table 13-2 Comparing Existentialism and Postmodernism

	Existentialism	*Postmodernism*
The Challenge	Finding meaning and value in a world without God	Unmasking the pretensions of reason
The Method	Creation of meaning and value	Interpretation of the text of human experience
The Danger	Nihilism: The surrender to despair in the face of the meaninglessness of existence	Oppression: The continued belief in narratives whose purpose is to support the dominant power structure

Review!

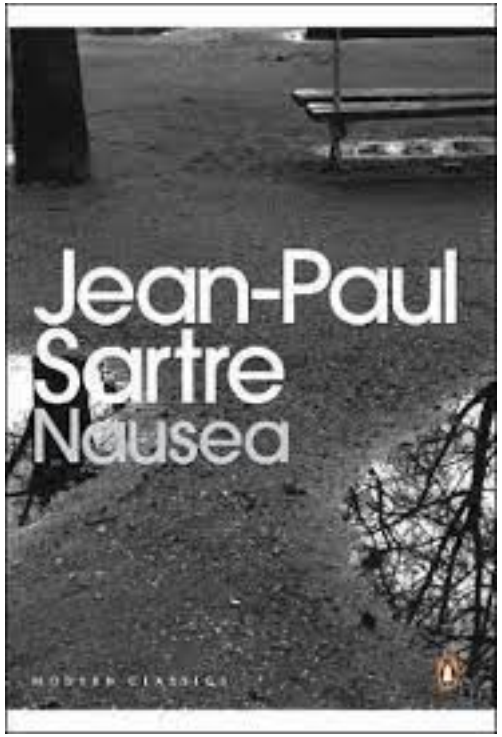
What are the six themes of existentialism?

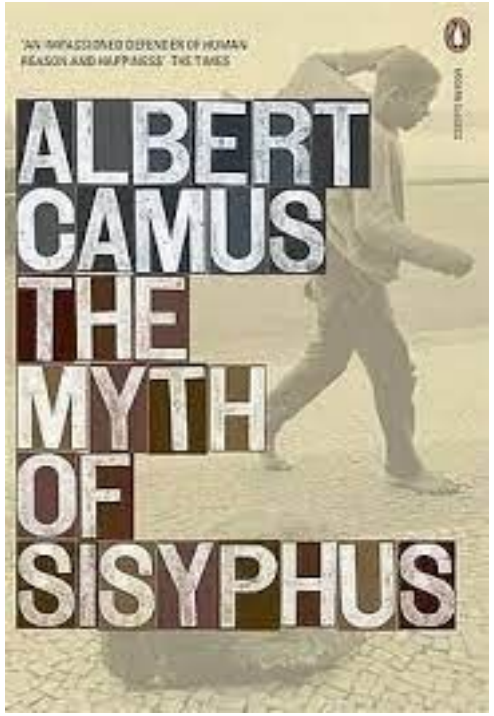
1. Existence precedes essence
2. Life is absurd
3. Alienation
4. Nothingness and Death
5. Fear, Dread, Anxiety
6. Freedom with responsibility

Literature review

Existentialist writing







Movie review



